

Descriptive and narrative composition

Paper 2 · Section B · 40 marks | syllabus 2027–2029

What you will learn

Craft sustained description or narrative with deliberate structure, imagery and accurate expression.

How this assessment works

All candidates take Paper 1. Centres then enter candidates for Paper 2 or the Coursework Portfolio. Speaking and Listening is optional and separately endorsed. The supplied June 2026 papers inform presentation only; question structure and word limits in this guide follow the 2027–2029 syllabus.

Description: a controlled scene

Description develops an impression through selected details, changes in focus and precise sensory language. There need not be a plot. Start wide, move to a revealing detail and finish with a changed impression. Avoid stacking adjectives or inventing all five senses when they are irrelevant.

Worked example

For “A place just after the rain”, begin with reflections across the empty pavement, shift to a single drop collecting on a shop sign and end as footsteps return.

Narrative: change under pressure

Narrative requires an event, a decision and a consequence. Establish a viewpoint, develop tension through action and pace, then close on a meaningful change. An ending need not be a twist; avoid introducing an unexplained dramatic event on the last line.

Worked example

For “The unexpected message”, a character receives a note, misreads its urgency, chooses to act and discovers that their relationship changes because of the decision.

Editing and alternative route

Both compositions are about 350–450 words and carry 40 writing marks. Leave time to check tense, paragraphing, punctuation and spelling. If your centre enters Component 3 instead of Paper 2, the portfolio has three assignments of about 500–800 words each: response to text(s), description and narrative. Optional Component 4 tests an individual talk and conversation and is separately endorsed.

Worked example

Revision pass: replace vague verbs; check viewpoint and time sequence; vary sentence lengths for a reason; remove repeated images.

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Date: _____

Answers and teacher guidance

Check your response only after finishing the practice. Responses can be expressed in other valid words when their meanings are supported by the source.

2. Teacher guidance: judge the relevance and development of material, control of structure, vocabulary, sentence craft and accuracy using the current official mark scheme. Model narrative for title (c), "The unexpected message" (about 375 words): The message arrived after the final bus had gone. Its six words made Lena read the date twice: "The seeds are yours. Open tomorrow." Her grandmother had closed the hillside garden three years earlier. Since then the gate had gathered rust, and each spring Lena had passed it without lifting her eyes. A number she did not recognise had sent the message. She typed a question, erased it and put the phone face down.

By morning, curiosity had overcome caution. She climbed the lane with the key that had hung, unused, beside the kitchen door. The lock turned with a scrape. Inside, the paths had disappeared beneath nettles, but the old bench still faced the mountain. A small paper envelope rested beneath a stone. It contained six beans and a note in her grandmother's careful handwriting: "For whoever remembers to begin again."

Lena sat down. She had expected an explanation for the text, perhaps even an apology for the silence of the past years, though there was no one left to give either. Instead, someone had brought the envelope here and wanted her to find it.

She took out her phone and called her brother. He answered on the second ring. "Did you send me a message?" she asked. "I did," he said. "I found the envelope when I was clearing the shed. I thought you might want to see the place before we decide what to do with it." She looked at the wild paths and almost said that selling the garden would be easier. Then a gust parted the nettles, showing the dark, workable soil beneath. "Come up," she said. "Bring gloves."

He arrived with two pairs and a flask of tea. They argued over which path to clear first, just as they had argued as children, and soon both were laughing. By late afternoon they had uncovered one narrow bed. Lena pressed a bean into the soil and covered it with her thumb. Nothing visible had changed. The bench was still weathered, the gate still stiff, and the rest of the garden was waiting. But when she left, she shut the gate carefully so they could open it again tomorrow. In your own work, sustain one chosen title for roughly 350–450 words; edit tense, paragraphing, punctuation and spelling.

Diagnostic answer

1: B

Source for assessment structure: Cambridge IGCSE First Language English 0500 syllabus for 2027–2029, <https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/718783-2027-2029-syllabus.pdf>. Original passages and questions by FagusED; June 2026 papers and mark schemes supplied by the user consulted for response layout and feedback style. This is independent study material, not an official Cambridge paper.